A SUMMARY OF THE ENTIRE HILCHOT SHABBAT IN 14 CLASSES

The Shabbat Kitchen Part 4: Grinding, Kneading and Pickling

Class 6 of 14

Series: Laws of Shabbat — a 14-part course

Shiur: 6 of 14

Topic: The Shabbat Kitchen, Part 4 — Tochen (Grinding), Lash (Kneading) and Me'abed (Pickling)

Recorded: Tiferet Eyal, Hendon — 27 November 2018

Note: The shiur was dedicated l'ilui nishmat of two departed souls, as announced at the start of the recording.

Recap

We have covered Bishul, leaving food on the fire (She'hiyah), Borer and Dash. Tonight, the remaining two big kitchen melachot — **Tochen** and **Lash** — and a brief word on **Me'abed**.

Part A — Tochen (Grinding)

Definition

In the Mishkan, the seeds for the dye were ground before being made into a paste. **Tochen** is not only "grinding" with a machine: it is making something big into **very small pieces** — grinding, **mashing** (avocado, banana), crushing, mincing, chopping very finely. How small is "small"? The poskim give no exact measure: as long as the pieces are not extremely fine, it is fine. A finely chopped Israeli salad is probably on the border but still acceptable.

Tochen applies to **non-food** too: shaving wood, crushing a clod of earth — relevant, for example, to dried mud on clothes.

Does Tochen apply to food that is already edible?

In the Mishkan the seeds were inedible. Some Rishonim hold Tochen applies only when grinding makes something edible (e.g. raw beetroot, which the Gemara discusses). **The final halacha: Tochen applies even to edible food** — so one may not grind or finely chop vegetables as a rule.

Grinding for immediate use

The Gemara explicitly permits Borer for immediate use, but says nothing about Tochen. The **Rashba** (13th century) argues the same applies: grinding with your hands for immediate eating is no different from grinding with your teeth — there is no melacha in the mouth; it is the way of eating.

Halacha: edible produce may be **mashed or finely chopped for immediate use** — for the upcoming meal, even if it lasts hours — combining both lenient views. E.g. mashing avocado for the meal about to start.

Never with a specialised instrument

Even when Tochen is permitted, use only ordinary cutlery — fork, spoon, knife; a **chopping board** is fine. A **grater, mincer, chopper or potato masher** is forbidden rabbinically as **uvda d'chol** (a weekday activity) — such tools are even **muktseh**. Electrical machines, of course, are forbidden.

Egg slicer: permitted — it slices rather than grinds, so it is not a grinding tool and not muktseh.

Q (peelers): a vegetable peeler is a Borer question rather than Tochen (see Shiur 5).

Food that does not grow from the ground

Meat, fish, chicken and eggs don't grow from the ground. Combining two disputes (edible food; non-plant food), **Tochen does not apply to cooked meat, fish or chicken, or to eggs** — even **not** for immediate use. Mashing eggs on Friday night for Shabbat morning is fine — still without a specialised tool.

Ein tochen achar tochen

Something already ground and re-formed — bread, cake, biscuits made from flour — may be crumbled again, even for later.

The handle of the knife

Doing a melacha in an **unusual manner** (*shinui*) normally reduces it to a rabbinic prohibition. But the Gemara treats mashing with the **back or handle of a knife or fork** (*kat ha'sakin*) as so unusual that it is **permitted outright** — for any food, even not for immediate use.

Practical examples

Case	Ruling
Mash avocado for the meal about to start	Permitted — edible, immediate use
Crush raw (uncooked) beetroot for now	Better not — inedible raw
Mash avocado on Friday night for the next morning	Only with the handle of a knife/fork
Mash a cooked piece of fish, now or later	Permitted — not from the ground and already edible
Chop salad extremely finely	Only for immediate use

Machines that make noise — *hashma'at kol*

Generally, what is set going before Shabbat may run during Shabbat (a garden hose). But some forbid letting a noisy machine — classically a **mill** — run on Shabbat, since people may think it was started on Shabbat.

- **Sephardim:** no such prohibition. A **washing machine on a timer** may run on Shabbat — perhaps not in the spirit of the day, but permitted if tucked away and not disturbing.
- **Ashkenazim** are stringent on noise.

- An **alarm clock** is permitted by all — everyone knows it is set in advance.
- Some forbid a **television** even switched on before Shabbat on this basis.
- **Q: a radio on a timer?** — Strictly speaking, yes (for Sephardim).

Part B — Lash (Kneading)

Definition

After grinding, the seeds were mixed with water into a paste. **Lash = binding small particles into a unified mass using a liquid** (water, oil, vinegar). The classic case is making dough. Making a sandwich is not Lash — no particles are bound together.

Two stages — and the key dispute

1. **Putting the ingredients together** (which begins the mingling).
2. **The act of kneading/mixing.**

View	What is forbidden
Shulchan Aruch, Rif, Rambam — Sephardim	Only the act of kneading/mixing
Ashkenazim	Both — even putting the ingredients together

Two kinds of mixture

- **Belila avah** — a thick, dense mass that won't pour, or moves only very slowly (dough): forbidden by the **Torah**.
- **Belila rakah** — semi-loose, pours slowly: forbidden **rabbinically**. (Something truly runny isn't Lash at all.)

The permitted method — criss-cross strokes

The Gemara permits mixing with a big *shinui*: **criss-cross strokes** — one direction, then the perpendicular one, **lifting the spoon out** between strokes — instead of the normal circular motion.

- **For Sephardim:** since only kneading is the problem, one may combine the ingredients on Shabbat and mix with criss-cross strokes — **even a thick mixture**.
- **For Ashkenazim:** the shinui helps only the kneading, not combining. So a **thick** mixture can be made on Shabbat only if the ingredients were combined before Shabbat. A **semi-loose** mixture (only rabbinic) is permitted with a minor change — e.g. **reversing the order** of the ingredients (oil first, then egg). Ashkenazim rely on the Sephardi view in special cases, e.g. for a child or an invalid.

When it binds by itself — beware

The leniency of combining ingredients assumes the mass forms only through your mixing. Where the ingredients **bind on their own** as soon as they touch, it is forbidden even for Sephardim. Example: **Weetabix with a little milk** — the milk is absorbed and binds the particles by itself. Pour in a **large amount** of milk so it stays runny, then mix with criss-cross strokes.

Thinning is fine

Adding liquid to **loosen** a mixture is the opposite of Lash and generally permitted — e.g. adding water to ready-made tehina that is already edible.

From the Rabbi's handout of practical examples

(The Rabbi distributed a sheet of common questions he had compiled; thanks to Michael for printing it.)

- **Tehina from ground sesame and water** — forbidden: it binds by itself.
- **Ready-made tehina, edible** — may add water to loosen it.
- **Ready-made tehina too thick to eat** — adding water makes it bind into an edible paste: use criss-cross strokes.
- **Aubergine salad with oil** — Sephardim: criss-cross strokes; for a looser version, oil first.
- **Egg and onion with oil or mayonnaise; liver with oil; tuna with mayonnaise** — usually thick. For Sephardim: combine and mix with criss-cross strokes.
- **Weetabix / porridge** — plenty of milk so it is runny, then criss-cross strokes.
- **Jelly** may be made on Shabbat, if there are no other issues.

Part C — Me'abed (Pickling)

Pickling is forbidden on Shabbat — e.g. putting a cucumber into a pickle jar. Reasons given: it resembles **cooking**, or **tanning** (changing the texture, like processing leather). Be careful with **salting vegetables** such as cucumbers and leaving them to stand — salt just before eating, or add **oil**, which neutralises the salt's effect.

Summary

- **Tochen** = making something into very small pieces, food or not. Permitted: edible produce for immediate use; cooked meat/fish/chicken and eggs at any time; already-ground foods (bread, cake); anything with the **handle** of a knife or fork. Never with a grater, masher or mincer; an egg slicer is fine.
- Noisy machines on timers (washing machine) — permitted for Sephardim; Ashkenazim are stringent.
- **Lash** = binding particles with liquid. Sephardim may combine ingredients and mix with **criss-cross strokes**; Ashkenazim need ingredients combined before Shabbat for thick mixtures. Beware things that bind by themselves (Weetabix, tehina from sesame).
- **Me'abed** — no pickling; don't leave salted cucumbers standing.

Coming Up

Break for Chanukah; the series resumes on **18 December**.

Shiur 7 — 18 December: Out and About — Horesh, Zore'a, Kotser

- Ploughing — walking with football studs or high heels, making holes in the ground, playing marbles or football
- Planting — putting flowers in a vase on Shabbat
- Harvesting — climbing trees, relaxing in a hammock attached to a tree

One more shiur before the winter break, resuming in January.

B'Ezrat Hashem

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